CETIRIZINE

Once daily

Mild sedation possible

CHEMICAL NAME (RS)-2-[2-[4-[(4-chlorophenyl)(phenyl)methyl]piperazin-1-yl]ethoxy]acetic acid (dihydrochloride)

CLASS Second-generation (non-sedating) H1 antihistamine

TRADE NAMES Zyrtec · Zirtek · Allercet · Cetrine

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Allergic rhinitis (seasonal and perennial), allergic conjunctivitis.
- Chronic urticaria (up to 4× dose under specialist).
- Pruritus from allergic conditions; insect bites.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily (evening if drowsy), with or without food.

DOSAGES

- **Adult & ≥12 yr:** 10 mg once daily.
- **6–11 yr:** 5 mg twice daily or 10 mg once daily.
- **2–5 yr:** 2.5 mg twice daily.
- **CrCl 30–49:** 5 mg daily; <30: 5 mg every 48 h.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 20–60 min. **Duration:** 24 h.
- Minimal metabolism (active metabolite of hydroxyzine).
- Excreted unchanged in urine. **t½:** 8–10 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Selective peripheral **H1 antagonist**; minimal CNS penetration and anticholinergic effect.
- Inhibits eosinophil migration.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Mild drowsiness (more than loratadine).
- Headache, dry mouth.
- Fatigue.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Urinary retention (rare).
- Hypersensitivity reactions.
- Aggression/agitation (rare, children).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity to cetirizine or hydroxyzine.
- Severe renal impairment (CrCl <10).
- **Caution:** epilepsy, urinary retention, alcohol.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Alcohol, CNS depressants:** possible additive sedation.
- **Theophylline:** slight ↓ clearance.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Adjust dose in renal impairment.
- Assess symptom control.
- Advise on drowsiness in some patients.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take once daily; may cause mild drowsiness; test before driving.
- Avoid alcohol.
- Stop 48–72 h before allergy skin testing.

KEY POINTS

- Non-sedating H1 antihistamine (mild drowsiness possible).
- 10 mg once daily.
- Renally excreted.
- Active metabolite of hydroxyzine.

SOURCES CHECKED **[485]** Cetirizine Dihydrochloride 10 mg Film-Coated Tablets (UK SmPC) **[486]** Cetirizine Hydrochloride, oral (US label) **[487]** Cetirizine HCl, oral (US label)

Full references p. 432–457